

East 17th Avenue. This shows the grand total of buildings erected in this city during 1896 to \$4,070,504.

WAS IT A SPECTER?

Strange Experience of Two of Ventura's Young Men.

[Ventura Free Press, Dec. 27.]

Parties returning from hunting trips to the mountains often tell strange tales of their experience, when miles away from human habitation, of conflicts with grizzly bears, mountain lions, etc.—but by far the most weird story we have heard is told by two well-known young men of this place, who were on a prospecting tour some three weeks since near Cobblestone Mountain, at the northern boundary of this county. The story they tell—and they are willing to take their oath on the truth of their statement—is about as follows:

One cold night they were simultaneously awakened about 12 o'clock by the noise of crackling brush that had been thrown on the fire. They arose to a sitting posture and saw the figure of an Indian woman standing by the fire. She was dressed in a robe of gayly-colored material that almost reached to her feet. A glistening necklace—evidently of gold and silver—encircled her neck, and hanging pendent from this were a number of bears' claws. Her black hair reached below her waist. In her ears were large hoop earrings of gold.

Upon seeing the form, one of the young men instinctively reached for his rifle, by his side, while the other stared in amazement at seeing such a sight in the dead of the night, and 30 miles from any house. When the figure saw the motion made to reach the rifle she motioned for them not to fire, and moved down the trail, backing to

When the figure saw the motion made to reach the rifle she motioned for them not to fire, and moved down the trail, beckoning to them. Before disappearing from view she again beckoned to them, but they were too dumbfounded to follow.

The next morning they followed the trail, and, after much difficulty, traced the footprints to the base of a high cliff, about a mile from their camp. The rest of the story told is to this effect: "When I awoke," said one of the young men, "I was horrified. I couldn't move to save my life. I was frozen with astonishment. The next morning we discussed the matter, and determined to investigate. So the next night we took our blankets and went to the base of the cliff. At about midnight, the same hour the figure appeared to us, we saw a bright, phosphorescent light on the brow of the cliff, and I am sure we heard a voice calling 'Meeneeah, Meeneeah,' several times. This is the strangest experience I ever passed through. I never have believed in ghosts, but I would like to know what this was. If it was a woman, how did she come there at that time, 80 miles from civilization?"

An old Indian tradition is to the effect that many, many years ago an Indian maiden—Meeneeah, the only daughter of a chief—was lost in this region, and starved to death near the place called Squaw Flat. It is said that different camping parties have seen this phosphorescent light spoken of, in the vicinity where these young men were camped. Can this be a parallel case with that of the Indian woman abandoned on the San Nicholas Island for eighteen years.
